
The Post-Truth Era Is Upon Us. The Correspondents' Dinner Attack Is the Latest Example.

Published by

Estimated reading time

6 min

Added on

2026-04-27

Address

<https://slate.com/news-and-politics/2026/04/white-house-correspondents-dinner-attack-cole-allen.html>

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Here's what we know about the attack at the White House Correspondents' Dinner on Saturday night: A man carrying two firearms tried to charge the event. He failed to kill anyone. Federal authorities are charging Cole Allen, a 31-year-old man from California, with firearm and assault charges, and they may add more as the investigation continues.

We do not yet fully understand the suspect's motivations, but we have strong indications. He had donated to Kamala Harris' presidential campaign, he had attended an anti-Donald Trump protest, and he had [sent messages](#) to family members before the attack denouncing the Trump administration. Investigators have said they believe he was attempting to shoot members of the Trump administration. Before the attack, Allen wrote an apology letter to his friends, colleagues, and family. "I am no longer willing to permit a pedophile, rapist, and traitor to coat my hands with his crimes," he [wrote](#), the Wall Street Journal and other outlets report.

Those signposts seemingly paint a straightforward picture of this attack as a politically motivated assassination attempt against the president and members of his administration. But if you ask observers—and particularly observers on the left—there's something even more sinister going on here.

In the hours after the incident, social media users began speculating that things weren't as they appeared, and that the shooting, some argued, had clearly been staged.

This was a popular enough idea that "staged" trended on social media Saturday night. Some [of the posts](#) on X that spelled out the conspiracy theory got several million views. One popular resistance lib account [polled](#) his followers, and more than 80 percent who responded said they believed the attack had been staged. And on X, Bluesky, TikTok and elsewhere, the comment sections are awash in accounts proclaiming the shooting a fake.

This is an administration that lies prodigiously, and so it's expected that there's a reflexive skepticism to any official recounting of events. But the evidence that these accounts are pointing to is thin, to say the least.

Some claims were based on the kind of false and confusing information that always circulates after a major news event with a lot of witnesses. Some were [skeptical](#) that a gunman could get into such a heavily guarded hotel. Others pointed to Karoline Leavitt's quip before the dinner that during Trump's speech there would be "shots fired." Others tried to analyze the [facial expressions](#) in photos of top administration figures, looking for something disingenuous to betray acting or indicate a lack of real fear. And some [pointed](#) to a Fox News broadcast in which the reporter's audio cut out—suspiciously!—right as she began to describe Leavitt's husband warning her, before the event, to be safe.

But the reality is that there wasn't any need for evidence: many of these users made their claims based on gut feelings. It made sense that Trump would stage an assassination attempt because, in their thinking, it's so clearly politically beneficial to the president. It could help him with his abysmal

approval ratings, which could turn out useful in the midterms.

Or it could justify his desire for a White House ballroom. This came to be the leading theory. Trump did argue, after all, in comments to the public and in a TruthSocial post that the incident proved the usefulness of a secure, official White House ballroom. (It's worth noting that the White House Correspondents' Association is unlikely to want to host its annual dinner at an official White House venue, given that press freedom is central to the celebration.) And MeidasTouch, the highly popular liberal influencer-media network, circulated a [compilation](#) of conservative influencers' posts making, in lock-step, Trump's same argument. To those who saw that post, the speed at which the conservative narrative developed around the ballroom seemed suspicious.

It's true that the attack will help Trump change the subject at a time when his myriad policy failures—particularly the war in Iran—have been front and center. And it's true that conservative voices are rapidly using the episode to defend Trump's desire for a ballroom, as well as to bolster their claim that the left is the main perpetrator of U.S. political violence. But none of that comes close to proving that the shooting was staged. Sure, the Trump officials may have not appeared as visibly shaken as people expected simply because the shooter wasn't actually anywhere near them—as one CBS News reporter [pointed out](#), the incident took place on an entirely different level from the ballroom, nowhere near where the president was. He was able to get into the hotel because the hotel was open to the public: the actual security perimeter was narrower. As for the Fox News audio bit, dropped calls are common during times of high cell traffic, such as after a major downtown Washington event coming to a sudden and dramatic end. And the unified conservative talking point, while not flattering to the intellectual independence of right-wing content creators, isn't exactly a new phenomenon.

The rapid impulse to insist the shooting was staged is further proof of just how deep we've ventured into a post-truth era, where anything that happens will be immediately engulfed in conspiracy theories. For a long time, the right was the only side dominated by feverish fantasies, but the shooting suggests the left is increasingly willing to join them in the swamp.

There are many places to point fingers when reckoning with our new, irrational state of affairs. There are algorithms that promote the most polarizing content and social media influencers with financial incentives to provoke. There are prominent conspiracy theorists elevated to positions of power by the Trump administration itself, creating a kind of arms race of vitriolic partisan speech between the two sides. There is the absurdity of the Trump years, which has caused a lot of people to question a lot of basic things. And there is the long-standing trend in the decline in public trust in institutions, undermining it all.

We have reached a point at which conspiratorial thinking in itself is its own kind of political movement—one that often exists outside traditional partisan lines. There are typical MAGA conspiracy theorists and BlueAnon accounts, decrying fantastical sinister plots from the Democrats and Republicans. But there are also those who are poisoned enough by the “question-everything” side of the internet so as to betray their own former allies. Chief among these are the former MAGA guys who have turned on Trump over Israel; many of them have bought into outlandish antisemitic conspiracy theories about Jewish cabals. And consider Candace Owens' conspiracy theories about Charlie Kirk's assassination: The man suspected of killing Kirk had a relationship with a transgender roommate and, according to the prosecution, held some leftist views. He was a perfect villain for the right. And yet Owens, a committed conspiracy theorist, refused to settle for the simple answer—instead [resorting to a mix of antisemitism and bizarre mysticism](#). Conspiracy thinking is starting to overtake partisan thinking.

For now, though, conspiracy thinking largely serves to either make Trump into a hero or a villain. There remains a difference between the right and left in that no Democratic politicians of any real prominence have yet endorsed these theories, whereas top Republican officials—and especially the president—continually feed the right-wing conspiracy machine. But as conspiracy theories are becoming an instinctual habit of the American public, we can expect to see more events like the White House Correspondents incident processed this way. Any sense of shared reality is shattered, and it's unclear how we might ever get it back.

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